

What you'll need:

- A Windows 10 ISO file from [Microsoft Windows Download Page](#)
- A USB flash drive (8 GB or larger)
- A backup of all important files (installation may erase data)
- Your Windows product key (if applicable)

Step 1: Create a Bootable Windows 10 USB

1. Download Microsoft's Media Creation Tool.
2. Run the tool and select **Create installation media**.
3. Choose:
 - Language
 - Edition: Windows 10
 - Architecture: 64-bit (recommended for most modern laptops)
4. Select **USB flash drive** and let the tool create the installer.

Step 2: Back Up Important Data

Before proceeding:

- Copy documents, photos, and other files to external storage.
- Export browser bookmarks if needed.
- Note software license keys for important applications.

Step 3: Boot From the USB Drive

1. Insert the USB drive.
2. Restart the laptop.
3. Enter the boot menu (commonly F12, Esc, F9, or F11 depending on manufacturer).
4. Select the USB drive.
5. Wait for Windows Setup to load.

Step 4: Start Windows Setup

1. Select:

- Language
 - Time and currency format
 - Keyboard layout
2. Click **Install Now**.
 3. Enter a product key if prompted.
 - If reinstalling on previously activated hardware, you can often select **I don't have a product key**.

Step 5: Choose Installation Type

Select:

Custom: Install Windows only (advanced)

This option allows partition management and a clean installation.

Partitioning Tips

Option A: Completely Clean Installation

Use when:

- You want to erase everything.
- You have already backed up your files.

Steps:

1. Delete all existing partitions on the system drive.
2. You should end up with **Unallocated Space**.
3. Select the unallocated space.
4. Click **Next**.
5. Windows automatically creates required system partitions.

Option B: Keep a Separate Data Partition

Example for a 500 GB SSD:

Partition	Suggested Size
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Windows (C:)	150–200 GB
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Data (D:)	Remaining space
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Steps:

1. Delete only the partitions you intend to replace.
2. Create a new partition for Windows.
3. Leave remaining space for data.
4. Format the partitions as NTFS.

Partitioning Advice

- SSDs perform best when you leave some free space available.
- For most users, 150–200 GB for Windows is sufficient.
- Avoid creating too many small partitions.
- Do not manually modify EFI/System Reserved partitions unless you understand their purpose.

Step 6: Install Windows

1. Select the target Windows partition.
2. Click **Next**.
3. Wait while Windows:
 - Copies files
 - Installs features
 - Reboots several times

Do not remove the USB until setup indicates it is safe.

Step 7: Complete Initial Setup

1. Select region and keyboard layout.

2. Connect to Wi-Fi if desired.
 3. Sign in with:
 - Microsoft account, or
 - Local account (if available during setup)
 4. Create a password and security questions.
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Privacy Settings

When Windows asks about privacy options:

Recommended Choices

Location

- Off unless needed.

Find My Device

- On for laptops.
- Off if privacy is a priority.

Diagnostic Data

- Required/basic only.

Inking & Typing Personalization

- Off unless you use those features.

Advertising ID

- Off.

Tailored Experiences

- Off.

Activity History

- Off unless you use cross-device features.
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Post-Installation Tasks

1. Install Windows Updates

1. Open:
 - Settings → Update & Security → Windows Update
2. Click **Check for updates** repeatedly until no updates remain.

2. Install Drivers

Check:

- Graphics
- Wi-Fi
- Bluetooth
- Audio
- Touchpad

Use:

- Windows Update first.
- Then the laptop manufacturer's support website if necessary.

3. Verify Device Manager

1. Press Win + X.
2. Open **Device Manager**.
3. Look for devices with warning symbols.

4. Enable Security Features

Verify:

- Windows Security is active.
- Firewall is enabled.
- BitLocker (if supported and desired) is configured.

5. Create a Restore Point

1. Search **Create a restore point**.
2. Enable System Protection.

3. Create a restore point.

6. Install Applications

Typical essentials:

- Browser
- Office software
- PDF reader
- Backup software
- Media player

Potentially Missing Details

Depending on the laptop model, you may also need:

- Instructions to disable or reconfigure Secure Boot.
- Instructions to switch between UEFI and Legacy boot modes.
- Storage controller drivers (rare on some newer systems).
- Manufacturer-specific boot key information.
- Steps for upgrading from Windows 7/8 instead of performing a clean install.